

Gregory of Elvira: On Noah's Ark (*De arca Noe*)

English translation by Luke J. Stevens, 2019

Translation

Tractate of Adamantius the Old On Noah's Ark

¹ *And the Lord said to Noah: The time of all men has come before me, for the earth is full of their malice. And, behold, I will destroy them and the whole earth. So, make for yourself an ark of squared woods, and you shall make nests and nests and pitch it.*

[Gen 6:13-14](#)

² If we should desire to examine with diligent care and careful attention the construction of that ark, through which the righteous man Noah merited to be saved from the shipwreck of the world, undoubtedly we shall find a great sacrament of spiritual grace arranged in its very measures and conjunctions. ³ For it thus says: *You shall make the ark three hundred cubits long and fifty cubits wide and thirty cubits high. You shall make for the ark an opening and you shall finish it a cubit higher. And you shall make an entrance brought down, and you shall make for it a second story and a third story, etc.*

[Gen 6:15-16](#)

⁴ Thus, this construction of the ark clearly revealed a type of our Church. But there is no doubt that Noah had a figure of Christ, as indeed from the Hebrew to the Latin language Noah is called rest, just as even his father Lamech, when he imposed the name, prophesied: *This one will make us rest from our works and the sorrows of our hands and from the earth, which the Lord has cursed.* ⁵ Therefore, as Noah alone in all the earth was found righteous, and with everyone having perished in the cataclysm of water, he alone with his household was saved, because he alone by living well had made himself pious to God, whom the world had angered by a contrary act, thus too when the Lord has come to judge the world in flame of fire, then will be ended the evils of men and of the fleeing angels and of the villainies of the whole world, but with the saints alone provided rest in the kingdom of the future age. For this ark, which was built of incorruptible woods, to be venerated, as I have said, revealed the construction of the Church, which is to remain with Christ forever.

[Gen 5:29](#)

[cf. 2 Thess 1:8; 2 Pet 3:7, 10-12](#)

⁶ The seven souls, however, who are given to the holy and righteous Noah, are recognized to have had a type of the seven churches, which through Christ are to escape the destruction of the fire of judgment and are to reign in the new earth

[cf. 2 Pet 3:7, 10-12](#)

with Christ. But perhaps it may disturb someone, why the churches are called seven, when one is spread upon the entire globe. Seven churches, thus, because of the septenary spirit, though it is one, are named plurally. ⁷ For just as *there is one body*, and seven are the members, or seven duties of the members—i.e., head, hands, feet, sight, hearing, taste, and smell—thus too the body of the Church is one, yet septiform by grace of the charisms. But also seven eyes of the Lord, and seven stars in the right hand of him seated on the throne, and seven golden candelabra, and seven lamps in the tabernacle of the Lord, and seven angels, seven trumpets, seven bowls, seven women seizing one man—i.e., the Church's virtues holding Christ—and seven columns in Solomon's house, with which the house of the Church is supported and built; ⁸ but also John the blessed apostle writes to seven churches, and Paul, an equally venerable apostle, gave epistles to seven churches likewise, though to the rest he wrote by name, so as not to exceed the number seven of the churches; for also the seven loaves of bread in the Gospel and the seven baskets full of fragments, overflowing, revealed an image of the septiform Church. And for that reason, divine Scripture says: *Noah entered into the ark and seven souls with him*.

⁹ Those seven souls revealed, as I have said, the seven churches; I shall briefly prove that in every single church there are the seven churches. For seven are the gifts of the charisms, as through Isaiah the renowned prophet the Lord has deigned to manifest: *And there will rest upon him the spirit of wisdom, the spirit of understanding, of counsel, of virtue, of knowledge, of piety, the spirit of fear of God*; ¹⁰ we cannot all have them all, but we individuals have single ones. But only Christ the Lord has all, whereby the body is whole; but in us, single ones, whereby we are counted as members. Therefore, whoever of the number of brothers consisting in one and in the same church have had the spirit of wisdom, these all having one charism make one church. ¹¹ Indeed, *church* means the congregation of the saints; lastly, the blessed apostle Paul, when he was writing to the Church, added what the Church is, saying: *to the saints and faithful*; and also through this whoever holy and faithful brothers have the spirit of understanding make another church as another class; also, by similar reason, whoever have the spirit of counsel make a third class as a third church; ¹² and those whom the spirit of virtue has filled are numbered as the fourth church; in the same way too those whom the spirit of knowledge has inundated are counted in the fifth church; thus too those whom the spirit of piety has united show the number of the sixth church, and those whom the spirit of the fear of God has conjoined are referred to the seventh church. ¹³ For when we are separate, we individuals have the single charisms; however, when we convene into one, we all make the one and whole and perfect septiform Church, whose is the body of Christ. These are the seven souls who were given in the destruction of water to Noah, who stretched forth an image of Christ. ¹⁴ For through water, as the righteous are saved, thus the sinners and the impious are punished, just as those seven churches in the end of the age, with all the nations perishing, through Christ are to be freed from the cataclysm of fire, as I have already said, and to perceive the glory of the heavenly kingdom, because, just as

1 Cor 12:12, 20

cf. Zech 4:10; Rev 5:6;
1:16, 2:1, 1:12; Exod
37:23; Rev 8:6, 15:7,
8:2; Isa 4:1; Prov 9:1

Rev 1:4

cf. Mark 8:5, 8

Gen 7:7, 13; cf. 1 Pet
3:20

Isa 11:2

cf. Rom 12:4; 1 Cor
12:12

Col 1:2

no one could evade the cataclysm of water, except who is reserved in the ark, thus too nobody can flee on the day of divine judgment, except whom the ark of the Catholic Church has sheltered.

¹⁵ That the ark, however, is referred to as having a second story and a third story evidently shows the places of the dwellings and the qualities of the habitations that are prepared for the saints in the kingdom of God. Indeed, in one story is a figure of paradise, in another of the new earth—where heavenly Jerusalem is to descend, so that there may be in it, just as it is written, *the habitation of God among men*; ¹⁶ of which earth the blessed John says: *And I saw a new heaven and a new earth and the heavenly city Jerusalem, descending from heaven onto the new earth*, and Isaiah: *Just as a new heaven and a new earth, which I make persist in my sight, so will your seed and your name persist, says the Lord almighty*—in the third story, the kingdom of the heavens.

¹⁷ Of there is what also our savior and Lord said in the Gospel: *Many are the habitations in the house of my Father who is in heaven*. Thus, however, is written of the kingdom of the heavens: *Blessed who suffer persecution because of righteousness, because theirs is the kingdom of the heavens*. Of the dwelling of paradise, however, the Lord himself by all means proves when he says: *To the victor, I will give to eat from the tree of life, which is in my God's paradise*. ¹⁸ However, he likewise manifests the dwelling of the new earth, when he says: *Blessed the meek, because they will possess the earth*; but also Solomon: *The holy will be left upon the earth, yet the impious will be expelled from it*. So, the same blessed Isaiah recalls again the qualities of these three dwellings, saying: *Those waiting on the Lord will renew their strength, they will be winged like eagles, they will run and not tire, they will walk and not hunger*. ¹⁹ They will by all means fly into heaven just like winged eagles, run in paradise and not tire, walk into the new earth and not hunger, because they will receive food there prepared by God. So, the Lord has also deigned to manifest through a parable this tripartite reason of the dwellings of the saints, saying: *The seed that fell on the good earth will bear fruit a hundredfold*. ²⁰ So, they will bear the hundredfold fruit who receive habitations into heaven; sixtyfold, who merit to dwell in paradise; thirtyfold, who are into the new earth. Whence already it should be plain to you that that three-story ark clearly revealed an image of, as I have often said, the Catholic Church, whose tripartite residences—i.e., of heaven, of paradise, and of the new earth—were formerly shown by the Lord.

²¹ Truly, what says thus that the construction of the ark itself was disposed so that the broader will be in the first, where it takes foundation, in the middle narrower, and in the third through four corners an opening is finished up to one cubit by a shortening measure, brought down having one window, this certainly signifies that in the first part of the construction—i.e., in the first dispensation of the saints—wider license and laxer discipline of all the fathers and patriarchs was indulged because of the offspring of their sons to be generated; and because it was to be permitted to them to do many things licitly and to more freely do what they wanted, therefore the greater and more spacious part of the ark was made first. ²² But the middle was rendered in a narrower measure, because in the middle

Rev 21:3

Rev 21:1–2, 10

Isa 66:22

John 14:2

Matt 5:10

Rev 2:7

Matt 5:4

Prov 2:21–22

Isa 40:31

Matt 13:8, 23

times, through the Law of Moses and the prophets, in a narrower and shorter space, by constricting precepts, the people had to be reduced. But the third through corners and by an opening finished into one cubit signified this, that through the four corners—i.e., the four Gospels—the construction of all the Church should be compressed: *Because tight and narrow is the way that leads to life*, and up to one cubit—i.e., up to the measure of the begotten man that the Lord assumed—all the framework of the Church had to be reduced.²³ Finally, no one can reach the peak of perfect virtue and glory except through the anguishes of tribulations and the pressures of persecutions, which also our Lord bore in his passion, just as it is written: *It is necessary that we through many tribulations enter into the kingdom of God*. But because it says: *in a cubit you shall finish it*, this one cubit is an image, as I have said, of the body of Christ;²⁴ which cubit is seen to pertain to the unity of the perfect man, of whom we are members, not to the measure of the status of the man; for we all are one in Christ Jesus. Therefore, into one cubit the construction of the ark was finished, because in Christ's one body and in the grace of his sufferings all the fullness of the Church had to be gathered.

Matt 7:14

Acts 14:21

Gen 6:16

cf. Eph 4:13, 5:30

cf. Gal 3:28

²⁵ For what it says that the raven sent out from the ark would no more return, this showed that the impure pleasures of men must be expelled from the Church and are to return no further. For the raven signified the pleasures of the deceitful and impure soul, and the infamy of its black color showed the unrighteous vice of sinners. But the dove that was sent, and, when it had not found rest in the world, returned again into the ark, revealed an image of the Holy Spirit, who, when he had been spread by the Lord in all the world and because of the iniquity of the world could not find peace in the home of all men, had to be called back into the ark of the Church,²⁶ just as the Lord himself in the Gospel instructs his apostles, saying: *When you come to each house or city, say: Peace to this house. If there is there a son of peace, your peace will come upon him; if, however, there is not there a son of peace, your peace will return to you*.²⁷ Accordingly, the Holy Spirit, when he still had not found rest upon the nations, because they had not yet believed in Christ, returned into the ark of the Church of the apostles, until, with the iniquities of sinners eliminated, there grew in all the nations the discipline of faith, as they merited to receive the Holy Spirit. Finally, Scripture subjoined: *And again he sent off a dove from the ark, and it returned to him around evening having an olive branch in its mouth*.²⁸ Therefore, what brought forth the olive branch clearly revealed the testimony of peace and resurrection and that the wood of the passion in its mouth, foretelling and presenting, has to grant the fertile grace of the charism; around evening, however, that it has to arrive in the end of the world.

Luke 10:5–6

Gen 8:10–11

²⁹ But the measure of the ark as a length of three hundred cubits evidently shows a figure of the Lord's cross; since three hundred among the Greeks is signified by the letter *tau*, which letter makes one apex as an upright tree, but the other extended as a yard on the head, and by all means showed the appearance of the cross; by this mystery both the length of life is given to the believing and the breadth of the new earth is granted and the height of the heavenly kingdom is prepared.³⁰ However, the fifty cubits of breadth of the same ark signified this, that

on Pentecost, i.e., the fiftieth day after the passion of the Lord's cross, the Holy Spirit would descend, through whom we hope to reach and to obtain both the hope of salvation and the glory of the heavenly kingdom.³¹ But the height of thirty cubits of the ark showed the Lord's age of thirty, because he baptized the man that he assumed through the office of John in the Jordan; for he was of thirty years, as the evangelist attests, when through the water of baptism he illuminated with heavenly gifts the man that, as I have said, he had undertaken.³² Therefore, there is a height in the measure of the age of Christ's body, just as the blessed Paul the apostle says: *until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, the perfect man to the measure of the age of the fullness of Christ, so that we may no longer be children*; however, the length to the passion of the Lord's cross, by which the believing are signified, the width to the day of Pentecost, on which the Holy Spirit came upon the believing.

Luke 3:23

Eph 4:13–14

³³ Therefore, most beloved brothers, you see that all the construction of that ark was sent ahead in the sacrament of the venerable Church, and that man cannot escape the destruction of the whole globe except through the Church, just as also in the cataclysm of the world nobody remained except those whom the ark had shut in.³⁴ And accordingly, we must work so that we ask God and our Lord with our whole heart, that the faithful in the Lord merit to stay in God's Catholic Church. For then the rewards will ensue, if with everything of peace and the pact of evangelical harmony the laws of the institution are kept by us, that we may be truly happy before the face of God the almighty Father.

Notes

Translated from the critical edition of the Latin by Bulhart in CCSL 69:149–55. The earlier critical edition by Vega is available [online](#).

Gregory of Elvira, writing ca. 360, is widely accepted as the tract's author, notwithstanding its heading. Parallels in his *Tractatus Origenis* may be compared. The Biblical text quoted is Old Latin.

The exegesis draws primarily from the lost writings of Victorinus of Poetovio, to which Gregory is an important witness. Close parallels may be found in Victorinus's extant works, as well as other authors likewise drawing from Victorinus's lost works: on the seven churches, cf. Fortunatian, *Comm. ev. M.* 81; on the three eschatological dwellings, cf. Chromatius, *Tract. Matt.* 54A.10.

The literature on this text is rather meager. Above all, see Martine Dulaey, "Le *De arca Noe* de Grégoire d'Elvire et la tradition exégétique de l'Église ancienne," *Graphè* 15 (2006): 79–102—available [online](#).